

INTRODUCTION: WOMEN, GENDER, AND CHANGE IN AFRICA

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The scholarship on women and gender in Africa has shown that women's political, social, and economic experiences are often fundamentally distinct from men's. Feminist and non-feminist scholarship has found that gender is a key factor in explaining this difference. However, the concept of gender and its use in the study of politics and society in Africa have been subject to debate, generating new insights into the topic. The articles in this virtual issue contribute to this literature by demonstrating the mutability of gender relations and by theorizing the links with major political and social phenomena including colonization, migration, and armed conflict. They show how, and explain why, these phenomena lead to shifts in gender norms within Africa and among African migrants living outside the continent. These articles also highlight the nexus between everyday survival mechanisms such as transportation businesses and antiretroviral (ART) treatment support groups, and the gendered politics of being male or female in those specific contexts. They also provide methodological insights into the study of gender relations and interrogate the dynamics of knowledge production in the areas of women and gender studies in Africa.

By focusing on shifts in gender norms in Africa and among migrant communities, the articles in this virtual issue depart from scholarship that has assumed the fixity of gender norms in these contexts. By underlining the impact of movement—migration, displacement, and transportation—on gender norms, the articles point to a fresh empirical perspective from which gender relations can be studied. The foregrounding of conflict-affected societies in these analyses contributes to testing recent hypotheses on the relationship between armed conflict, evolving gender norms, and women's economic, political, and social advancement. Furthermore, by examining the production of knowledge on women and gender in Africa from perspectives that are often marginalized, these articles extend debates on the future of women and gender studies in Africa.

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Women and gender in Africa

A major theme in the debates around gender in Africa has been the appropriateness of the concept for studying African societies. Scholars have questioned the universality of gender and its relevance in ordering relations in specific precolonial societies.¹ While these perspectives have been challenged, and the concept of gender widely adopted in scholarship and in practice, it remains important to interrogate how it operates in societies and its interactions with all types of political and social phenomena in Africa.² Thus, scholars have begun to explore how women's roles and status have been affected by issues such as armed conflict.

Consequently, we know that the scope of economic and political roles performed by women has increased after conflict.³ Indeed, the end of conflict has opened doors to women's political participation in African countries.⁴ This increase in women's political participation has formed part of a change in the gender regimes in some countries and has been attributed to the decline in conflict.⁵ This decline in conflict is linked to gender normative change through gender disruptions, women's movements' activism, and the spread of new international gender norms.⁶ The legacies of armed conflict have also contributed to an increased role for women in the implementation of gender-based violence policies.⁷ In Liberia, the relatively open political environment and the political and economic support from international organizations facilitated the efforts of the women's movement.⁸ However, women's advancement in post-conflict settings has been found to be neither linear, nor uniform, due to social and structural barriers that constrain and undermine gains made in the aftermath of armed conflict.⁹ Furthermore, scholars have called into

1. Ifi Amadiume, *Male daughters, female husbands: Gender and sex in an African society* (Zed Books, London, 1995); Oyeronke Oyewumi, *The invention of women: Making an African sense of western gender discourses* (University of Minnesota Press, Minneapolis, MN, 1997).

2. For a discussion of this perspective see Bibi Bakare-Yusuf, 'Yorubas don't do gender': A critical review of Oyeronke Oyewumi's *The invention of women: Making an African sense of western gender discourses*. <https://www.codesria.org/IMG/pdf/BAKERE_YUSUF.pdf> (2 September 2019).

3. Veronika Fuest, 'This is the time to get in front': Changing roles and opportunities for women in Liberia, *African Affairs* 107, 427 (2008), pp. 201–224.

4. Ibid. Jennie E. Burnett, 'Gender and balance and the meanings of women in governance in post-genocide Rwanda', *African Affairs* 107, 428 (2008), pp. 361–386. Gretchen Bauer and Hannah E. Britton, 'Women in African parliaments: A continental shift?' in Gretchen Bauer and Hannah E. Britton. (eds), *Women in African Parliaments* (Lynne Rienner, Boulder, CO, 2006), p. 1–30.

5. Aili Mari Tripp, *Women and power in post-conflict Africa* (Cambridge University Press, New York, NY, 2015).

6. Ibid.

7. Peace A. Medie, 'Fighting gender-based violence: The women's movement and the enforcement of rape law in Liberia', *African Affairs* 112, 448 (2013), pp. 377–397.

8. Ibid.

9. Marie E. Berry, 'Barriers to women's progress after atrocity: Evidence from Rwanda and Bosnia Herzegovina', *Gender and Society* 31, 6 (2017), pp. 830–853.

question the durability of post-conflict gains, and by extension, shifts in gender norms and relations. Therefore, this body of work has provided important insights into how gender norms and relations are affected by armed conflict. Five of the nine articles in this virtual issue contribute to this literature by studying shifts in gender norms and relations due to armed conflict, but also, due to other political and social phenomena, including international and internal migration. The arguments presented are essential for understanding the fluidity of gender norms but also raise important questions about the impact, depth, and sustainability of the observed changes.

In his article on Ethiopian migrants to France, Samson Bazebeh studies how the disruptions caused by migration altered gender relations, including in marriage.¹⁰ The article is important for its focus on African migrants to countries of the European Union and its analysis of their experiences based on in-depth interviews and participant observation over a nine-month period. Focusing on members of the Abo Ethiopian Orthodox Church in Paris, the author explains that 'As migrants exercise their agency in order to survive and navigate across state restrictions, they are forced into situations during which they may reassess their identity and community and ask questions about their morality and values.'¹¹ Thus, migrants questioned expectations around issues such as women's sexual relations and romantic relationships, including marriage, and deviated from shared values and norms in these areas. Both male and female migrants perceived romantic relationships as not delivering on the mutual help and care as a result of the disruption caused by the process of crossing borders. However, shifts in gender norms do not result only from international migration.

Tim Gibbs's study of domestic migrants in Johannesburg's minibus taxi business demonstrates how societal fragmentation produced new patterns of migrant masculinity.¹² Recent work has shown the connections between politics and the transportation business.¹³ Gibbs shows how new forms of mobility, triggered by the end of apartheid and neoliberal fragmentation produced 'new patterns of patriarchal aggrandizement', including of patriarchal home building.¹⁴ Among other things, taxi men organized their households around networks of mobility, positioning men to engage in relationships with 'various combinations of wives and girlfriends,' based

10. Samson A. Bazebeh, 'Africa's unholy migrant: Mobility and migrant morality in the age of borders', *African Affairs* 116, 462 (2016), pp. 1–17.

11. *ibid.* pg. 10

12. Tim Gibbs, 'Becoming a "big man" in neoliberal South Africa: Migrant masculinities in the minibus-taxi industry', *African Affairs* 113, 452 (2014), 431–448.

13. Daniel E. Agbibo, 'Informal urban governance and predatory politics in Africa: The role of motor-park touts in Lagos', *African Affairs* 117, 466 (2018), pp. 62–82.

14. Gibbs, 'Becoming a "big man"', p. 431.

on their place in the hierarchy of taxi men.¹⁵ These two articles illustrate how migration shapes society's expectations of, and transforms relations between, men and women. The third article in this virtual issue studies how another political phenomenon—armed conflict—alters gender norms.

With post-conflict Côte d'Ivoire as a case study, I draw on interviews and focus group discussions to theorize women's decision to report rape to the police and gendarmerie in Abidjan and Bouaké.¹⁶ While rape remained highly underreported, girls and women were more likely to disclose rape to these agencies when they received encouragement and support from relatives and friends, termed allies. This finding diverges from much of the literature that finds survivors' networks to be barriers to reporting rape and other forms of gendered violence. Furthermore, focus group discussions showed frustration with the high levels of rape during and after the country's conflict and thus, more support from men and women for involving the state in the adjudication of rape cases instead of relying on community chiefs. The support for the intervention of the state in an issue that has mostly been resolved within the family and community shows how the violence of conflict had begun to alter what was viewed as the appropriate response to this form of gender-based violence. This speaks to the literature on the impact of armed conflict on gender norms and on women's rights.

Jonny Steinberg's article is an ethnography of ART treatment groups in the Eastern Cape of South Africa in order to understand 'what those who embraced ARTs did with it'.¹⁷ The high prevalence of HIV/AIDS in South Africa has had both political, economic, and social implications. In his study, Steinberg found that some of those on treatment were able to 'command the new technologies of AIDS treatment and bend them to new purposes'.¹⁸ He describes within treatment groups a 'powerful hierarchy' with young women at the top.¹⁹ These women, using biomedical and 'conversion' language, warned treatment group members, including men, against smoking, drinking, and taking any traditional medicine while on ART drugs, although there was little medical basis for these warnings. The author concludes that the warnings were more to 'silence familiar male discourses in the support groups themselves and thus to seize control, as it were, of the uses to which talk of ART is put'.²⁰ Steinberg also observed freer and more playful discourse on sexual desire within the group. Overall, these feminized spaces were also public forums in which women could

15. Ibid, p. 443.

16. Peace A. Medie, 'Rape reporting in post-conflict Côte d'Ivoire: Accessing justice and ending impunity,' *African Affairs* 116, 464 (2017), pp. 414–434.

17. Jonny Steinberg, 'Re-examining the early years of antiretroviral treatment in South Africa: A taste for medicine,' *African Affairs* 116, 462 (2016), pp. 60–79.

18. Ibid. p. 70.

19. Ibid. p. 70.

20. Ibid. p. 73.

participate, the rules of which they could build and amend, unlike most public forums in the community.

The fifth article in this issue also focuses on a non-traditional role assumed by a woman. Neil Carrier and Cynthia Nyamweru draw on interviews and ethnographic fieldwork to explore the rise of a female leader in opposition to colonialism in Kenya.²¹ They study female leadership through the historical figure of Mekatilili wa Menza, who is considered to have played a key role in encouraging the Giriama to resist colonialism between 1912 and 1915. Mekatilili challenged the oppressive norms of colonialism through organizing resistance to colonial authority. She also focused on cultural change and morality through issues such as inconsistent pricing and the wearing of short skirts by Giriama women, a reflection of the patriarchal society. She was lauded for her masculine qualities and her actions defied gendered expectations and mirror the actions of individual African women as well as movements that fought against colonialism across the continent. Thus, while not an example of a shift in gender relations, this study demonstrates how colonialism spurred women to play roles that were predominantly assigned to men.

It is also important to interrogate how knowledge on gender norms, and on women and gender more broadly, is produced. Scholars have noted the strengths of certain methods, including interviews, in the study of women and gender in Africa. They have also underscored the importance of reflexivity and the positionality of the researcher in this area of enquiry. Olajumoke Jacob-Haliso's article demonstrates how the identity of the researcher affects the type of information they are able to collect during fieldwork.²² She examines how the researcher and the research participant's intersecting identities influence access to research participants and to data. Discussing her research with female Liberian returnees, the author finds that she gained access to certain insights and knowledge because of her identity as a Nigerian, a wife, and a mother. Jacob-Haliso draws on her extensive field experience to argue that 'motherland (or nationality) and motherhood (or maternity) produce 'minefields' during fieldwork that a researcher has to navigate in achieving different levels of access to research subjects, particularly in post-conflict situations'.²³ Indeed, Yolande Bouka found in her fieldwork in Rwanda that her identity as a black woman enabled her to access information that others did not, but also noted that this was mediated by intersecting identities including her nationality.²⁴ This

21. Neil Carrier and Celia Nyamweru, 'Reinventing Africa's national heroes: The case of Mekatilili, a Kenyan popular heroine', *African Affairs* 115, 461 (2016), pp. 599–620.

22. Olajumoke Jacob-Haliso, 'Intersectionalities and access in fieldwork in post-conflict Liberia', *African Affairs* 118, 470 (2018), pp. 168–181.

23. *Ibid.* p. 168.

24. Yolande Bouka, 'Researching violence in Africa as a black woman: Notes from Rwanda' (Working Paper Series, *Conflict in Difficult Settings*, 2015).

emphasis on reflexivity and analyses of positionality are particularly relevant for the burgeoning scholarship on conducting fieldwork in conflict-affected settings.

Gediminas Lesutis also probes aspects of positionality by discussing the challenges that come with representing the narratives of the marginalized.²⁵ Drawing on his research of enforced population resettlements due to coal mining in Tete, Mozambique, the author explains that narratives are co-constructed by the researcher and research participants and that these narratives are influenced by the socio-material context in which the narrative is embedded. Lesutis argues that 'these methodological aspects of the politics of narrative should be reflected upon as a way to navigate complex ontological narratives that emerge in one's fieldwork, as well as to overcome the potential danger of fetishizing individual agency or overlooking the broader structural inequalities'.²⁶ Social network approaches have the potential to reach populations on the margins of society. In their research note, Zoe Marks and Patrycja Stys articulate the conceptual and methodological contributions that social network approaches can make to the study of African politics due to the centrality of social networks in Africa.²⁷ They discuss various ways in which gender affects women's social networks, including by impeding their ability to access high status individuals. The discussion of considerations for conducting social network fieldwork suggests that social network approaches have the potential to excavate normative changes within communities and to reach populations that are rarely centred in research.

Ryan Briggs and Scott Weathers' article, however, shows that much work needs to be done to ensure that African scholars are adequately represented in African politics scholarship.²⁸ The authors show that Africa-based scholars, both men and women, are underrepresented in African studies journals. They attribute this to factors such as journal expectations and the incentive structure in African universities. Recent scholarship has also shown that scholars based in Africa, and in the global South more broadly, are greatly underrepresented in gender and politics journals published in the global North, although journals published in the South are more representative.²⁹ It has been argued that inclusion is necessary for equality, knowledge advancement, and for what it symbolizes to students

25. Gediminas Lesutis, 'The politics of narrative: Methodological reflections on analysing voices of the marginalized in Africa,' *African Affairs* 117, 468 (2018), 509–521.

26. Ibid. p. 510.

27. Zoe Marks and Patrycja Stys, 'Social Network Research in Africa,' *African Affairs* 118, 471 (2019), pp. 375–391.

28. Ryan Briggs and Scott Weathers, 'Gender and location in African politics scholarship: The other white man's burden?' *African Affairs* 115, 460 (2016), pp. 466–489.

29. Peace A. Medie and Alice J. Kang, 'Power, knowledge and the politics of gender in the Global South,' *European Journal of Politics and Gender* 1 (1–2), pp. 37–54.

in the global South and North.³⁰ Indeed, this virtual issue demonstrates the importance of diverse perspectives in the production of scholarship on women and gender in Africa.

Conclusion

This virtual issue features articles on the cutting edge of research on women and gender in Africa. The articles draw on and feed into key debates about women, gender, and change in African societies. Individually, the articles advance original arguments that enhance our understanding of themes such as migration, political participation, and peacebuilding. A thread that runs through these articles is how these social and political processes are affecting how men and women interact and expectations around what is appropriate and acceptable behaviour. The articles point to several directions for future research.

They underline the need to further interrogate gender relations in Africa and among African communities elsewhere in order to understand the conditions that lead to change, the mechanisms through which these normative changes occur, the patterns of change, and the durability of these changes. The articles point to other directions for future research. They demonstrate the importance of studying the ways in which evolving gender norms impact women's rights and wellbeing. In Côte d'Ivoire, it removed some of the impediments to women's accessing justice.³¹ It is important to understand how it has manifested in other contexts. The articles also show that the positionality of the researcher needs to inform data collection, analyses, and writing and that this is a topic that needs more attention in the literature. They demonstrate that scholars studying conflict-affected (and all other) societies should carefully consider how their identities (e.g. as African or non-African) have determined the kind of information they have been able to collect. More attention also needs to be paid to how the analyses and presentation of this information can better take into consideration the positionality of the researcher during the data collection process. This approach to research has the potential to produce knowledge that explicates how a range of political, social, and economic phenomena has contributed to shifts in gender norms in Africa.

30. Ibid.

31. Medie, 'Rape reporting in post-conflict Côte d'Ivoire'.